

ICI PERSPECTIVES IN CURATING NO. 1

Thinking
Contemporary
Curating

Terry Smith

INDEPENDENT CURATORS INTERNATIONAL

Thinking Contemporary Curating is the first in a new publication series developed by Independent Curators International (ICI) entitled *Perspectives in Curating* which offers timely reflections by curators, artists, critics, and art historians on emergent debates in curatorial practice around the world.

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A Curator's Last Will and Testament

- ① PASSION
- ② AN EYE OF DISCERNMENT
- ③ AN EMPTY VESSEL
- ④ AN ABILITY TO BE UNCERTAIN
- ⑤ BELIEF IN THE NECESSITY OF ART+ARTISTS
- ⑥ A MEDIUM - BRINGING A PASSIONATE+INQUIRY UNDERSTANDING OF WORKS OF ART TO AN AUDIENCE IN WAYS THAT WILL STIMULATE, INSPIRE, QUESTION.
- ⑦ MAKING POSSIBLE THE ACTS OF PERCEPTION

Nick Waterlow. *A Curator's Last Will and Testament*, 2009. Video still from *A Curator's Last Will and Testament*, 2012. Juliet Darling in collaboration with Father Steve Sinn S.J., DVD or Blu-ray, 11.5 min., continuous loop

The Lure

When it comes to showing art, do curators think in ways that are unique to their profession? Can curatorial thought be distinguished from the thinking processes within the myriad of closely related practices—especially art criticism, art history, and art making—and from curating within other kinds of museum or display spaces, public and private? Every exhibition demonstrates that curators reflect on circumstance, wrestle with ideas, develop research programs, and spark insights. Yet the discourse of art curators about curating—curatorial talk—while passionate and committed, seems routinely satisfied with rhetorical gestures, knowing asides, and ostensive demonstrations. For a profession driven by the desire to communicate with art's publics, its enabling dialogue is surprisingly inner-directed. Why is the substance of curatorial thinking so rarely articulated? It seems to me that this question has surfaced (become public) within a vast, rapid, and quickening change in the conditions within which curating is now undertaken. These changes require a different kind of thinking than that which served during modern times. They lead to a key question, to the exploration of which these essays are devoted: What is *contemporary* curatorial thought?

I raise this question at a time when curating is everywhere being extended, encompassing every kind of organizing of any body of images or set of actions. The title of curator is assumed by anyone who has a more than minimal role in bringing

about a situation in which something creative might be done, who manages the possibility of invention, or even organizes opportunities for the consumption of created objects or orchestrates art-like occasions. Google invites us to curate our profile, Picasa our very own image gallery. Certain restaurants proudly display menus curated by a food expert. A leading department store boastfully advertizes the name of its curator of jewelry. A gallery proudly acknowledges the designer of its elaborate opening event as its curator. On the front cover of a brochure, the Whitney Museum encourages members to curate their own 2012 Biennial by planning their attendance at the events constituting the exhibition. The underlying thrust of these usages is made explicit in projects such as net entrepreneur Steven Rosenbaum's Curationnation.org, which is devoted to advising businesses on "How to Win in a World Where Consumers are Creators," curation being understood as aggregating "manageable, inviting, online experience" from within the "chaos of digital noise."¹

Within the art world, the title "curator" has for some time expanded beyond the confines of those who care for collections and stage exhibitions in art museums to include those in museums who curate what are now regarded as core programs, such as education. Museums routinely name guest or adjunct curators who organize exhibitions on invitation. This practice and the myriad activities associated with it has become itself a professional subfield under the title "independent curator." An increasing number of practitioners seek shelter under its bright-yet-fragile umbrella. These range from the few

¹ Steven Rosenbaum, *Curation Nation: How to Win in a World Where Consumers are Creators* (New York: McGraw Hill, 2010), <http://curationnation.org/pages/aboutthebook>.

celebrated international artistic directors of biennials and mega-exhibitions (most of whom have at least one part-time institutional base) to do-anything interns whose actual working conditions make them foot soldiers in globalized capitalism's outsourced armies of cultural producers in whose ranks the thrill of being seen to be doing something cool stands in for the slim prospect of being paid, sometime, for their labors.

Although museums have not been abandoned, art curating is no longer necessarily tied to them, except by conservative definitions that draw a distinction between the *curator* devoted above all to the care and conservation of collections and the *exhibition maker* who does only, or mostly, what the name suggests.² Instead, curating now encompasses not only exhibition making but also programming at many kinds of alternative venues, and is often adjunct to even the most experimental art space. A recent issue of the online magazine *On-Curating.org*, for example, focuses on "aspects of the public sphere, public space, and public art in seven different metropolises around the world," from Zurich through Istanbul to Shanghai and Mexico City, with not even a passing mention of museums.³ The entire schedule of performance art events constituting Performa 11 was, of course, curated by director RoseLee Goldberg, while nearly every event was itself curated by someone other than the performer. There were fifty-five curators in all. Brooklyn-based artist William Powhida, scathing critic of the financial domination of the contemporary art world, described his sensationalizing manipulation of decadent stereotypes to draw attention to his 2010 show at Marlborough Gallery, Chelsea, in these

² A distinction drawn, for example, by Robert Storr in his essay "Show and Tell," in Paula Marincola, ed., *What Makes a Great Exhibition?* (Philadelphia: Philadelphia Exhibitions Initiative, 2006), 14. Museum-based exhibition makers looking for an introductory compendium of sound advice about how to conduct their profession in an honorable fashion will find this an extraordinarily useful essay, as are the contributions by Carlos Basualdo, Lynne Cooke, and others to this anthology.

³ *On-Curating.org* 11, no. 11, "Public Issues," n.d., http://www.on-curating.org/documents/oncurating_issue_11111.pdf.

4 Cited in Carolina M. Miranda, "Biting the Hand that Feeds Them," *Art News* 10, no. 11 (December 2011): 89.

terms: "Part of the goal was to use the press to curate hype."⁴ If it is done in a certain way and according to a certain spirit, it seems that even the critical interrogation of curatorship itself can be curated: for example, activist, performance artist, and academic Lissette Olivares was listed as curator of "A Symposium of Curatorial Interventions," held at the Gallatin School of Individualized Study, New York University, on November 17, 2011.

Which way and in which spirit? A current and widely shared answer goes along these lines: "Curating is caring for the culture, above all by enabling its artistic or creative transformers to pursue their work. This facilitation is done, preferably, with empathy and insight, effectively, and with some style." Such an answer might serve as a job description within the Omigod, iwaslike whirl of getting on with the exigencies of this project while looking for the next one, but it does not identify the distinctive elements of contemporary curatorship and it does not qualify as a definition of contemporary curatorial thought.

Some seem to doubt that curators are capable of critical thought.

Given the ageing of postmodernism as a critical category, but also the absence of any plausible replacement for it, the contemporary has become the default cultural periodization for the artistically current. It is, however, notoriously difficult to specify the contemporaneity of contemporary art. Nevertheless, notwithstanding reservations

about its suitability, "contemporary art" has been taken on as the generic name for the post-postmodern art that began to emerge in the 1990s, but that is only now receiving the serious and sustained attention that it demands if it is to be taken as a critical, rather than a merely journalistic or curatorial, category.⁵

Notice the instinctive distinctions drawn in this otherwise quite accurate remark about the use of the term "contemporary" for today's art and the less accurate remark about the time lag in critical discourse getting around to treating the contemporary critically. Curators reading this passage may find themselves appalled, as I was, by its implication that their thought amounts to something equivalent to journalism and that it cannot by categorical definition ever become critical.

In fact, the elements of contemporary curatorial thinking can be readily identified. Curators regularly speak about them, reflect on them, and share them with others. They amount to a concrete mix of principles, values, ideas, rules of thumb, and ethical necessities. The seven points that English-born Australian curator Nick Waterlow, director of a number of Sydney Biennales, wrote in his notebook shortly before his untimely death in November 2009 are a particularly poignant instance. Entitled, with dreadful prescience, "A Curator's Last Will and Testament," they read:

1. Passion; 2. An eye of discernment; 3. An empty vessel; 4. An ability to be uncertain; 5. Belief in the necessity of art and artists; 6. A

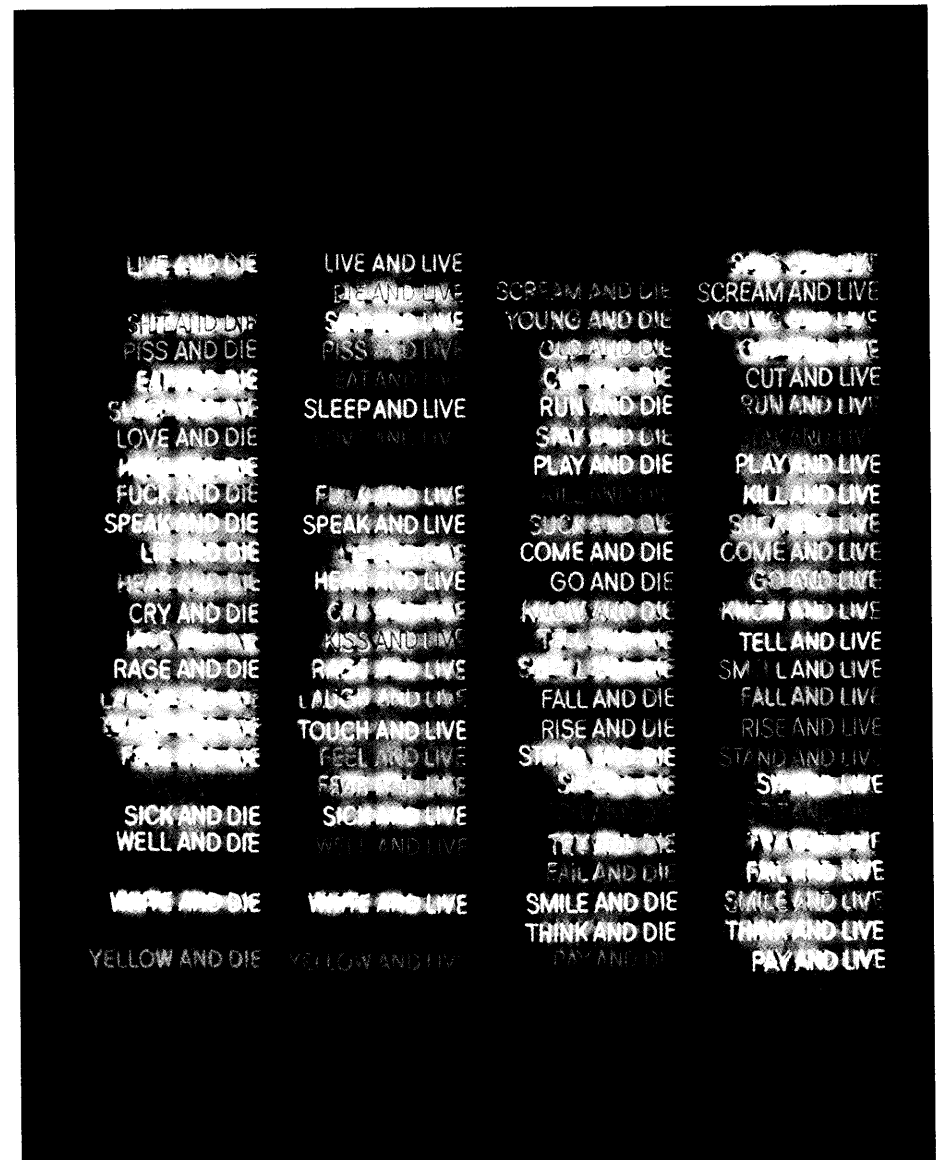
5 Avanesian and Skrebowski, "Introduction," in Armen Avanesian and Luke Skrebowski, eds., *Aesthetics and Contemporary Art* (Berlin: Sternberg Press, 2011). My grumble about the time-lag remark is occasioned by the fact that some of us have been attempting to theorize contemporaneity critically since the 1990s—in my case, in publications since 2001. It is true, however, that this effort has only been taken up more widely in the past two or three years.

6 A film by Waterlow's partner, Julie Darling, entitled *A Curator's Last Will and Testament*, was screened in Sydney in April 2012. (See page 16)

medium—bringing a passionate and informed understanding of works of art to an audience in ways that will stimulate, inspire, question; 7. Making possible the altering of perception.⁶

Values such as these resonate within more programmatic efforts by curators to reimagine museums; write the history of curating; innovate within exhibition formats; extend curating into educational activity; and, in some cases, commit to activist curating in venues beyond the art world. These impulses are reshaping modern curatorial thinking. They are crucial to its efforts to become contemporary. Less obvious in the discourse as yet, but equally important for the future, are issues such as rethinking spectatorship, engaging viewers as co-curators, and the challenge of curating contemporaneity itself—in its present, past, and future forms.

What follows are five essayistic tracks into this volatile territory—each drawing freely on adventures in the art world during the past year as I responded to ideas, events, and encounters as they occurred to me—leavened with occasional retrospective diversions and with some attention to the burgeoning literature on curating. To get the flavor of what I am attempting, imagine “Thinking Contemporary Curating” as three words in Bruce Nauman’s *100 Live and Die* (1984), centerpiece of the Benesse House Museum on Naoshima island, in the Inland Sea of Japan, in which rows of sets of words on either side of “and” flash on and off randomly in brightly colored neon. Think of the terms of my title as three ideas that flash independently, in bold isolation, but then combine into a number of



Bruce Nauman, *100 Live and Die*, 1984. Neon, 299.7 x 335.6 x 53.3 cm. Collection Benesse Holdings, Inc, Japan

almost sentences, seemingly located at levels below and more basic than those allowed by the surfaces of spoken and written language, through which they often, these days with accelerating insistence, break.

I do not write as a curator by profession, having been involved in making just a few exhibitions.⁷ I am, rather, an art historian, critic, theorist, and teacher who is a professional visitor to exhibitions and an amateur enthusiast about them. I have, over many years, learned an enormous amount from the efforts of curators—from the most collection oriented to those who would never think of setting foot in a museum. These reflections are a respectful attempt to offer something in return. I owe my first glimpse of art to a curator. Coming from a family for whom original art was out of the question, and going to primary schools where it existed, unremarked, as reproduced decoration, I discovered art by what I thought was an accident. At the age of nine, my father took me to visit the Museum of Natural History, Melbourne, to see the dinosaurs and the effigy of Phar Lap, a great racehorse, when I noticed in a cabinet at the bottom of some stairs what I thought were colored sketches for comic books of the kind I was making at home. Climbing up to the landing, another cabinet housed fine line drawings of extraordinary intensity. When I reached the top of the stairs, looking for more, a wonderful vista opened in both directions: vigorous battle scenes, lustrous figures, and dreamy landscapes. This was the National Gallery of Victoria, then as now stocked with a major collection of art from Europe, courtesy of the Felton Bequest, and

7 My curatorial record is modest and has always been undertaken as part of productive collaborations: *The Situation Now: Object or Post-Object Art?*, inaugural exhibition, Contemporary Art Society Gallery, Sydney, July 16–August 6, 1971 (with Tony McGillick); *Dreams, Fears, and Desires: Aspects of Australian Figurative Painting 1942–62*, S. H. Ervin Gallery, Sydney, Newcastle Regional Gallery, and Monash University Art Gallery, Fifth Biennale of Sydney and Power Institute of Fine Arts, University of Sydney, 1984 (with Christine Dixon and Virginia Spate); consultant curator, along with eight others, *Global Conceptualism: Points of Origin*, Queens Museum of Art, New York, 1999; and consultant to *The Achievement of Albert Kahn*, University of Michigan Art Gallery, Ann Arbor, 2001. I have also served on the boards of the Museum of Contemporary Art, Sydney, 1989–2000, the Australian Centre for Photography, Sydney, 1996–2000, and the Andy Warhol Museum, Pittsburgh, since 2002.

from Australia, courtesy of local donors, mainly artists. The images that had attracted me on that stairwell were drawn from the gallery's unmatched collection of William Blake's illustrations to Dante's Divine Comedy and its set of Blake's etchings of the Book of Job. Years later, Dr. Ursula Hoff, Curator of Prints and Drawings, told me that she placed them there in the hope that they would do for the youth of the city exactly what they did for me.⁸ This is curating as laying out the lure.

In these essays, I think alongside the thoughts about curating expressed by a number of curators, looking for traces of the constituents of contemporary curatorial thought, such as those listed a few paragraphs back. These essays are also a set of provocations. They urge curators to complicate thinking about "the contemporary" and to grapple with the challenges of curating contemporaneity.

8 On Dr. Ursula Hoff, see Sheridan Palmer, *Center of the Periphery: Three European Art Historians in Melbourne* (Melbourne: Australian Scholarly Publishing, 2008).

1.

What is
Contemporary
Curatorial
Thought?

In a recent essay, "The State of Art History: Contemporary Art," I track the usage of the term "contemporary" in art discourse during modernity and propose an art-historical hypothesis about contemporary art. I try to set out a framework in which we might identify the precise shape of the act of thought—the affective insight—that contemporary life requires of its art, of the criticism of that art, and of the history of that art: the (necessary, but never sufficient) kernel from which, via many vicissitudes, art must be made and criticism and history written. All kinds of inherited inspirations, medium constraints and possibilities, and many still-vital artistic trajectories remain relevant to such making and writing. Nevertheless, our experience of contemporaneity—of the multiple, various ways of being in time today, contemporaneously—is disposing art, criticism, and history in different ways, and is requiring fresh concepts, mediums, and languages. This is my conclusion:

Place making, world picturing, and connectivity are the most common concerns of artists these days because they are the substance of contemporary being. Increasingly, they override residual distinctions based on style, mode, medium, and ideology. They are present in all art that is truly contemporary. Distinguishing, precisely, this presence in each artwork is the most important challenge to an art criticism that would be adequate to the demands of contemporaneity. Tracing the currency of each artwork within the larger forces that are shaping this present is the task of contemporary art history.¹

¹ Terry Smith, "The State of Art History: Contemporary Art," *Art Bulletin* 112, no. 4 (December 2010): 380.

Is it possible to be as concise about what contemporaneity—our current condition—is asking of art curatorship? Perhaps it is. If so, the first step is to recognize that the object of contemporary curating is much larger than contemporary art. It must encompass all other art: art from any and every past, current art that is not contemporary, as well as projective, future art. (Some artists, in fact many, envisage art that is not subject to this past-present-future triad. Curators will follow; some are already on this trail.) Like contemporary art, contemporary curating is embroiled in time, but not bound by it; entangled with periodizing urges, but not enslaved to them; committed to space, but of many kinds, actual and virtual; anxious about place, yet thrilled by dispersion's roller-coaster ride. It does not follow a set of rules; rather, it adopts an approach arising from an emergent set of attitudes. Can we say that the purpose of curating today is something like this: To exhibit (in the broad sense of show, offer, enable the experience of) contemporary presence and the currency that is contemporaneity as these are manifest in art present, past, and multitemporal, even atemporal? It follows that what is understood in the art world as "Contemporary Art," while it does in fact inspire contemporary curating of all kinds, including exhibitions of art from previous periods, does not bind curators to its time-bound imperatives.

By art, to put it at its minimum, I mean any intentionally created existent that, following processes of searching self-reflection and including consideration of previous and other imaginable art, embodies its being and establishes its relationships with its anticipated viewers,

primarily through visual means. To exhibit is—again following such processes—to bring a selection of such existents (along, perhaps, with other relevant kinds), or newly created works of art, into a shared space (which may be a room, a site, a publication, a web portal, or an app) with the aim of demonstrating, primarily through the experiential accumulation of visual connections, a particular constellation of meaning that cannot be made known by any other means. Of course, such meaning may be parsed in terms other than strictly exhibitionary: art critical, art historical; literary, philosophical, cultural; personal or idiosyncratic; ideological or programmatic—the list is long. But exhibitionary meaning is quite specific because it is established and experienced in the space of an exhibition, actual or virtual (virtual includes memory).² The parsings, therefore, are translations from curatorial into other expository and interpretative languages.

It follows from what I have said thus far that, broadly speaking, contemporary curating aims to display some aspect of the individual and collective experience of what it is, or was, or might be, to *be* contemporary. Thus there is a spatial and phenomenological horizon for contemporaneity within the exhibition: it is a discursive, epistemological, and dramaturgical space in which various kinds of temporality may be produced or shown to coexist.³ Enabling viewers to experience contemporaneity *in an exhibition setting* (taking “exhibition” in the broad sense mentioned, and “setting” to mean any appropriate situated context) would, through this reading, be the curatorial equivalent of making contemporaneity visible in the case of art and

² This is a more specific meaning than the “exhibition value” that Walter Benjamin ascribed to all works of art that, as distinct from cult objects within ritual settings, are shown as art, and, since the early twentieth century, have been reproduced as widely disseminated images, especially as photographs and film. See his essay “The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technical Reproducibility,” in Walter Benjamin, *The Work of Art in the Age of Its Technical Reproducibility and Other Writings on Media*, ed. Michael W. Jennings, Brigid Doherty, and Thomas Y. Levin (New Haven: Harvard University Press, 2008), 25ff.

³ This phrasing owes much to a comment by João Ribas, who recalls in this context Le Corbusier’s 1939 design for a Museum of Unlimited Growth, a maze-like structure developed from the spiral of a seashell. A recent realization of this concept would be SAANA’s twenty-first century museum at Kanazawa, Japan.

of capturing it in writing for publication in the case of criticism and history. I am assuming that exhibiting artistic meaning is the main task of the contemporary curator, to which all other roles are subservient.

Yet while this might bring us to the same kernel of meaning that I got to (I hope) for contemporary art criticism and history writing, it does not fully distinguish what is unique to curatorial thinking. To do so would be to identify the kind of act of thought, the sort of affective insight, that contemporary life requires of curating in a way that it asks it of nothing else. What, then, is contemporary curatorial thought?

THINKING CONTEMPORARY ART

In the *Art Bulletin* article, as well as in *What is Contemporary Art?*, there is a crucial step in my argument where I set out, under the headings “Curators in Contention” and “Curators Stage the Debate,” the ways in which, in the years around 2000, Kirk Varnedoe, Okwui Enwezor, and Nicolas Bourriaud offered competing perspectives on the prevailing direction of contemporary art.⁴ Their insistence, respectively, on a continuity of modernist values within contemporary art, the arrival of a worldwide postcolonial constellation, and the small scale yet portentous emergence of a relational aesthetics, are examples of the kind of curatorial insight into contemporary art that I am talking about. Note that these are different kinds of ideas: the continuity of modernism is an idea about the current profile of art’s autonomous evolution (how art develops by persisting through all the non-art forces that act upon it); the

⁴ Terry Smith, *What is Contemporary Art?* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2009), 259–64. For classic statements of each of these positions, see Kirk Varnedoe, *Modern Contemporary: Art at MOMA since 1980* (New York: Museum of Modern Art, 2000); Okwui Enwezor, “The Postcolonial Constellation,” in Nancy Condee, Okwui Enwezor, and Terry Smith, eds., *Antinomies of Art and Culture: Modernity, Postmodernity, and Contemporaneity* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press, 2008), 207–34; and Nicolas Bourriaud, *Relational Aesthetics* (1998; Dijon: Les Presses du Réel, 2002).